

Reading Skills

Q. 1. Write a brief note on Reading?

In one of Bacon's essays, "Of Studies" he wrote, "*Reading maketh a full man, conference a ready man and writing an exact man.*" Bacon says that reading is such a miraculous thing that can make a man complete. It's really a great truth. According to Gray, "*Reading is a form of experience.*" It means reading trains our mind and broadens our outlook.

In fact, reading is such a complex communicative way of receiving and interpreting the written words. It involves the recognition of the written material and the comprehension of it, that is, understanding the **main** and **subsidiary** points as well as links between different **parts** of the written material. During the reading process while receiving and interpreting the written words, the reader is mainly concerned with decoding, comprehension, text analysis and response.

On the **whole**, reading is a skill that helps readers receive information with proper understanding. However, reading at a leisurely pace may not be useful and effective. The reading skill definitely requires **practice**. It is a visual, **kinetic** and cognitive skill, which means that different people are **likely** to practice reading at varying skill levels.

Q. 2. What is reading comprehension?

It is the ability to focus on the reading material, take it in and retain it. It is the whole process of comprehension while increasing reading speed, no matter who the reader might be.

Some researchers on reading have argued that the process of increasing the reading speed decreases comprehension. This is both true and untrue, and the threshold for reading with good comprehension is different for different people and changes with the amount of reading practice.

Usually, reading at less than 100-200 words per minute (wpm) is the normal rate for learning and 200-400 wpm is the normal rate for understanding or comprehension. When you go beyond reading 500 wpm can compromise the quality of reading and your understanding or comprehension.

There are some ways to balance reading pace and comprehension. Effective speed reading techniques can help you read faster without compromising your comprehension. For this, we focus on the techniques that include familiarization with the reading material and minimizing subvocalization.

READING SKILLS: SKIMMING & SCANNING

Q. 3. Briefly explain skimming and scanning as techniques of developing reading skills.

Or

What do you know about reading skills? Discuss skimming and scanning briefly.

There are some particular reading skills which are used while reading a piece of text but here we are going to discuss two very important reading skills - skimming and scanning - which are very common and helpful while reading a text for comprehension in a certain given time. These two reading skills are also very important from the examination point of view because exams are also time bound. So, the students must try to thoroughly understand these two reading skills for securing good grades. Let's discuss them.

Skimming and Scanning

The reading skills, i.e. (id est) skimming and scanning are used for rapid reading. They are quite different from each other and are used for different and particular purposes. They aren't meant to be used all the time for all sorts of purposes. When we talk about the speed reading range, skimming and scanning are at the fast end. On the other hand, studying is at the slow end. Readers who know the reading skills of skimming and scanning are called flexible readers. They read purposefully and try to get the information they need quickly without wasting their time. They read speedily by skipping many unimportant words, phrases, clauses and sentences. They avoid reading everything, rather they read thoroughly the important chunks of the text. They apply their skill in knowing what specific information to read and how to do it.

- Q. 4. Describe the skimming skill and discuss when and how the skimming skill is used/applied.

What is Skimming?

Skimming is a kind of fast reading to read a long extract of a reading in less time. It is used to understand only the general or main ideas of a reading. It is the most appropriate reading technique in order to understand non-fiction (or, factual) text. With this skill of skimming, you don't read all the text. Rather, you just read the important things and your overall understanding is partial and limited because you don't read everything. The focus remains on only those parts of the text which are important to your purpose. At a certain point while reading a text, the skimming skill also gives us an opportunity to look for details in addition to the important aspects of a reading.

When to Skim?

We can't apply the technique of skimming for all kinds of texts because skimming is done at a fast speed with less-than-normal understanding. However, skimming is very useful at certain times when you have to read 5-6 books and the same number of articles on a certain topic in order to give an oral presentation in a few days.

Skimming is done to locate the information quickly while sparing some time wisely. It will help increase the amount of usable material you obtain for your research.

Skimming is also very effective while preparing for the examination in a few days. You can revise your lessons very easily by skimming. In short, skimming is done when you are going through:

1. a non-fiction text
2. a long text that is to complete in a short timespan
3. a text about which you have some prior knowledge
4. a text which can be skipped.

If you pick and choose carefully what you skim and skip, you will happily be surprised at the large amount of data you have gone through in a short period of time.

The Method of Skimming

Skimming is a method of quick reading for the partial or limited comprehension of an extract of a text. This method of rapid reading

involves both horizontal and vertical readings. But mostly we rely on the vertical reading of a text to save time. The horizontal reading is done to mostly read the complete introductory paragraph, topic sentences of the paragraphs and the complete concluding paragraph of a text. The vertical reading is done to skip the lines between the two topic sentences of the two separate paragraphs and it goes till the last or concluding paragraph of the text. Through vertical reading, we try to look for the main or important aspects of a text. It means we don't need to read everything in the text. What we read is more important than what we leave out. So what material do we read and what material do we leave out?

The Steps of Skimming

Let's understand the skimming process step by step:

1. Read the complete introductory paragraph of the text by horizontal way of reading.
2. If you find an introduction described in more than one paragraph, you will read word by word all introductory paragraphs.
3. Now, after having enough understanding about the main ideas of the text, focus on the topic sentences of all the paragraphs included in the text.
4. Read the topic sentences of all the paragraphs in the body of the text to understand the main ideas.
5. If you do not get the main idea in the topic sentence or if the paragraph greatly interests you, then you can read more for having a proper understanding.
6. After getting the main ideas from the topic sentences, you may skip some words/lines or jump at the important pieces of information, such as names, dates, or events described in those paragraphs.
7. Continue to read only topic sentences of the text by going through the rest of the paragraphs until you are near the end.
8. Now stop skimming and read in detail the last part of the text because it may contain a conclusion or summary.
9. If you have understood the main ideas, your skimming will be successful.

- Q. 5. Describe the scanning skill and discuss when and how the scanning skill is used/applied.

What is Scanning?

Scanning is a useful reading skill for reading and understanding a specific part of a text. While scanning, you read quickly and try to reach a specific fact or piece of information without reading all the text. You scan when you look for your favorite film listed in a catalog, for a friend's contact number in a telephone directory or for the correct answer of a puzzle in a newspaper. For successful scanning, you need to understand what you read so you can search and find the specific information you require. Through scanning, you can quickly comprehend details and other information in a text.

Benefits of Scanning

At your college, during the reading activities, you might have scanned a text without knowing and taking notice of it. But now with the information provided in this section of scanning, you can use the scanning skill more **intentionally, frequently** and aptly. The more you practice it, the more **effective** it will become.

The most **important** benefit you gain from the scanning skill is the ability that **helps** you become a more **flexible** reader. The scanning skill adds another high gear to your reading and comprehension.

Another **benefit** of the scanning skill is that it allows you not to read every word. You can leave or overlook some words or lines by skipping the text to **reach** and find your **required** specific part of the information. By and large, **skimming** allows you to not read everything.

When to Scan?

You scan a text in these situations:

1. When you want to read and understand a specific piece of information from a text.
2. When you are preparing yourself for an oral presentation. At that time, you want to read and understand a specific concept from different books, web sites, and research articles. Scanning helps a lot in such a situation.
3. When you try to search the answer to a question from the given text in a certain time limit.

Tips for Scanning

While scanning, the use of your hand, especially the index finger, is very helpful in locating the specific portion of a text. You often make use of your hands to locate a word in a dictionary, to find a meeting time on your calendar, to read a train or bus schedule etc. The use of your hand or finger is no doubt very helpful in focusing your attention and retaining your point of the place while scanning a column of a text. Your peripheral vision can also help you scan effectively. When your finger moves down a list of names, you see not only the name your finger is pointing to but also the names above and below in that list. Keep your eyes active and search for the specific part of the text.

While scanning, keep the key words in your mind. Your target area of the text will give you a clue regarding the key words. For example, you are searching for the time a train leaves from Gujranwala City for Lahore. Here the key words to remember are "time" and "from Gujranwala City". Similarly, if you are looking for the price of an LED with the model number KA-715, the key word to locate in a list of LEDs is "KA-715".

The Arrangement of the Text You Scan

The text you scan is typically arranged in the alphabetical, non-alphabetical, chronological, categorical or textual format of the text. Alphabetical writing is written from A to Z. Text in non-alphabetical order can be a written list of TV programs. Chronological text is written time wise or in a numerical order. Categorical text is found in the form of a written list of some items of the same category like a stationery catalog. Textual form of the text is found in the form of the written paragraphs such as paragraphs written in a personal diary.

READING SPEED

Q. 6. What is the importance of reading speed?

Your reading speed determines how fast you comprehend some textual information. Your ability to read fast makes you able to find some information quickly. So, it helps you grab the textual information on which your success depends. For example, an employee with a looming deadline or a student preparing for an examination can understand that there is too much to read in a short available time. Therefore, it is very important to enhance your reading speed.

The Type of Reading Material

A great speedster, who can read 300 words per minute, can speedily go through fiction or magazine articles that are of great interest. However, difficult textbook material that contains new and obscure vocabulary will likely decrease the top reading speed of any speedster of reading materials. This is a negative effect.

On the other end of that scale, if you are in search of the specific information which is needed quickly, then an experienced reader from you will switch to "skimming", a reading skill that scans down a page while searching for keywords. This is the positive effect.

Reader's Motivation

To motivate the reader for the development of a greater reading speed can also bring a positive effect to your reading speed. Motivation can be done for either pleasure or profit. For pleasure's sake, you read the best-selling books and for profit sake, you digest large amounts of material quickly at school and on the job duty.

Mental and Physical Health

Both mental and physical health can affect a reader's speed in both positive and negative ways. A reader's speed of mental cognition will affect reading speed. Similarly, physical handicaps such as readers requiring glasses or contacts to see clearly will face problems. Reading is both a physical task and a mental one, so the speedy work of the reader's eyes can possibly affect reading speed.

Medium of Reading

The medium of reading can affect reading speed in both negative and positive ways. Skills with slight differences are needed to read a rolling television script, a computer screen, an electronic tablet, the screen of a cell phone, a printed book or even a newspaper. The medium is held differently, the words display differently, and the information is formatted differently. Some speed reading programs display text one word at a time, challenging the reader to immediately recognize the word and associate it with the previous words to develop comprehension.

Eyes can see only a few words clearly

Our eyes can see only a few words with clarity. The sharpest eyesight depends on the fovea in the retina. While gazing at a text, the only part you can see clearly is the part hitting the fovea. Nature allows it the visibility of about four to five words. Therefore, our eyes do not glide through the line while reading quickly, rather they move

in saccades. In other words, our eyes focus on about four to five words in one gaze and then focus on the next four to five words and so on. Such a limited number of words that the eye can see at one time and the brief stops at each visual field slow down reading speed.

Stop reading in low-light.

Do try to read in plenty of light. You're much less likely to fall asleep with the light left on if it's bright. Reading is done best if there's plenty of light.

Folding over Page Corners

Avoid doing this action otherwise maybe you find a bookmark on your book and in such way the life of the book will decrease. If you don't do this, you'll be able to keep your books in good condition so you can read them again and again.

Don't stay in your comfort zone.

Don't read books of only one genre of your liking. Try to read a book from a genre you wouldn't usually pick up. Be it crime, fantasy or nonfiction, you could be missing out and not even know it.

Resist the temptation of reading the last page first.

This habit takes you away from the satisfaction of finishing the book. Try to read a book this summer without skipping forward at all.

Avoid watching the film before reading the book.

Avoid watching a book-to-film adaptation of a book you've been thinking of reading. After having analyzed both genres, you will find a great difference between both of them.

Note: All the above-mentioned obstructions or hindrances can be minimized with the help of some reading techniques or skills.

HOW TO IMPROVE OR ENHANCE READING SPEED?

Q. 9. How can you improve or enhance your reading speed?

Here are some tips to improve reading speed:

1. Remove Distractions

To improve reading speed, try to reduce regressive eye movements. For this, try to read in an isolated environment with few distractions. In this way, you will not have interruptions and you will not have to re-read the read part of the text too often.

2. Increase Your Vocabulary

To increase your vocabulary or familiarity with more and more words will definitely increase your word fluency and hence it will improve your reading speed. While comprehending a text, you can see a difficult word. At that moment, you will do one of these three things:

1. Stop and try to understand the sense of that word
2. Stop, go back and re-read the preceding words to guess the meaning of the word from the context
3. Stop and search the meaning of that word from the dictionary.

The above-mentioned factors will slow down your reading. Therefore, increasing your vocabulary will improve your reading speed.

3. Inferring the Meanings

One of the best ways to avoid stopping at a difficult word is to infer the meanings of the difficult words. It can be done with the help of the clues, structure and contextual understanding of the text. So, this technique will also enhance your reading speed.

4. Chunking Words

Reading multiple words at one glance is called word chunking. Avoid reading words one by one rather the best way of reading is word chunking. In this way, you read three or four words at a glance while moving along a textual line. So, it will definitely improve your reading speed.

5. Use Your Peripheral Vision

Your peripheral vision is the vision occurring outside the point of fixation. To use your peripheral vision means that you do not have to fixate on every word in a line when reading. The best way to do this practice is to start reading from the second word in each line and end at the second last word in that line. This will improve your reading speed.

After mastering two words in the beginning and two words at the end of the line, you can start from the third word in each line and end at the third word to the end. Some readers become the best speedsters who just look at the middle of the line and understand the words to the left and right of the middle part with their peripheral vision. In this way, they read line by line instead of word by word.

6. Meta Guiding

To guide your eyes visually by using a pointer or a finger that moves faster along a line of text is called meta guiding. In this practice, you run your finger along the lines faster than your typical reading speed and your eyes follow your finger speedily. This technique decreases fixations at words and improves the reading speed. This technique will also decrease subvocalization and you will stop reading words in your mind.

7. Use a Speed Reading Tool

It is a tool that improves reading speed by reducing fixations. Such a speed reading tool flashes words to you at a speed (usually faster than your reading rate) using a Rapid Serial Visual Presentation (RSVP). The goal is to read the words as they are rapidly shown on the screen.

It is a tool that improves reading speed by reducing fixations. Such a speed reading tool flashes words to you at a faster speed than your typical reading rate by using Rapid Serial Visual Presentation (RSVP). You try to read the words shown on the screen as quickly as possible. This technique improves your focus and reduces fixations at words by training your eyes to catch words quickly. AccelaReader is one of the best speed reading tools available in the market. This tool gives you the facility to set the number of words per minute that the tool should flash for you. With this tool, you can also set

1. the number of words you want to flash at once,
2. the text size and so much more.

8. Take a Speed Reading Course

Such a course

1. improves how information is fed to the eye,
2. reduces fixations at words,
3. reduces subvocalization,
4. reduces regressive eye movement, and much more.

During the course, an expert can guide you to read faster in different ways. For instance, now you know that speed reading tools help but you may not know how to optimize their use. In such a course, amongst other things, you'll learn different ways to maximize the use of the AccelaReader speed reading tool. You will also get essential eye training and learn many time-tested methods to

increase your reading speed. Some such methods are the 20% method and the IRIS method. You can enroll yourself in the online course, Iris Reading's Speed Reading Foundation Course, for a comprehensive guide on speed reading.

9. Skimming

Skimming is a way of reading rapidly to get an overview of the text you are reading. You just try to be familiarized with it and understand the main points. The skimming skill can improve your reading speed by increasing your reading pace and improving comprehension.

10. Scanning

Scanning is another reading skill that enhances your reading speed. In this reading skill, only the specific part of the text material is comprehended. Unnecessary parts of the text are totally ignored. So, it saves time and enhances reading speed.

11. Be on Track While Reading

Try to focus on **what** you read and **avoid** distractions to avoid re-reading. It can **slow** down your pace and your comprehension.

12. Track Your Progress

Tracking your progress will also help you to improve your reading speed by **setting a time during your practice**.

13. Pre-viewing

Reading speed can also be improved by previewing the layout, headings, subheadings, indentations and multiple fonts of composing the text.

14. Anticipation

On the basis of your previous knowledge or understanding of the text, you can anticipate the next information easily. Here the titles and subtitles may help you understand the concept before long. So, it will enhance your reading speed.

15. Silent Reading

It's another way of improving your reading speed by reading silently. It will create a direct link between a visual impact and comprehension. As compared to the loud reading, it will not take much time while pronouncing words with their stress and proper intonation patterns. Hence, it will enhance your reading speed.

16. SQ3R

In this term, *S* stands for *Survey*, *Q* stands for *Question*, the first *R* stands for *Read*, the second *R* stands for *Recall* and the third *R* stands for *Review*. From the above-mentioned denoted words, it means a unique methodical way that will systematically improve both the reading speed and the comprehension.

STRATEGIES TO IMPROVE READING SKILLS

Q. 10. Define strategy and mention some important strategies to improve your reading skills?

Strategy is where you will focus your efforts to achieve your goals and how you will succeed or "where to play and how to win." It defines a specific course of action that will take you from where you are now to where you want to be.

It is possible to improve your reading skills in a number of ways. Listed below are **some strategies** you can use to improve your reading skills:

Set goals before reading.

First of all, set some reading goals for yourself in order to enhance:

- your vocabulary,
- your understanding of the text, and
- your ability to connect what you read with your own perspectives.

If you are successful in achieving your goals, you will be able to improve your reading skills.

The purpose should be determined.

Whatever the text may be, you should determine the purpose of that text before you start reading it. Your purpose of reading may be finding information, following the given instructions or enjoying the story. Think for a moment to consider why that text was written and what meanings or themes can be derived from it. Similar practice can be done for any type of text. When you know why you are reading a text, you can look for key ideas and details that support the purpose.

Practice previewing and scanning in advance.

To improve your reading skills, always try to preview and scan over texts before reading. By doing this, you can preview titles,

captions, headlines, and other text features to be familiar with the text you are going to read. This strategy will help you understand the basic ideas of your text you are going to read.

Apply different strategies while reading.

Try to enhance your comprehension by applying different strategies as you read different texts. If you preview a text, you may identify its structure as informative, persuasive or instructional. You might also identify key features of different texts such as the central themes, problems, solutions and comparisons. So, you can improve your reading skills by applying such important strategies.

Take notes while reading.

Taking notes while reading is an effective way to improve your reading skills. Suppose you are reading fiction, you may take notes to gain a deeper understanding of the author's language choices. Similarly, you can note down **new words** while reading a law journal. Now you can make **connections** between **your** points and the text you are reading. Likewise, charts, tables and **diagrams** can simplify themes and ideas and help you draw inferences from your reading.

Summarize what you read.

You can **improve your reading skill** by summarizing what you have read. In order to remember and understand what you have read, you might want to share information with a friend or write a short summary on a blank page. So, comprehension exercises like summarizing can be very beneficial.

Practice reading a text daily.

You can improve your **skills** by reading practice daily. For this you just need to spare 10 to 15 minutes daily for reading practice. To practice your reading skills, you can read newspaper articles, fiction, magazine articles, etc.

To sum up, by improving your reading skills, you will be a better communicator and better speaker in your career.

THE SCALE OF SPEED IN WORDS PER MINUTE

Q. 11. What is the formula for finding the scale of your speed?

Also give the table of different scales of speed.

You can find your reading speed by the following formula :

$60 \times \text{Total No. of Words/Time in Seconds} = \text{Words per Minute}$ | 277

The Scale of Speed	
Slow	Words Per Minute
Average	170-200
Above Average	200-250
Fast	250-300
Very Fast	300-400
	400-above

AVERAGE READING RATES BY AGE AND GRADE

Q. 12. Give the table of average reading rates by age and grade. According to "Oral Reading Fluency Norms" (2017) by Hasbrouck & Tindal and Marc Brysbaert's "Review and Meta-analysis of Reading Rate" (2019), the table given below gives the average reading rates by age and grade level:

Grade Level	Age	Words-per-Minute
1	6-7 years old	53-111 WPM
2	7-8 years old	89-149 WPM
3	8-9 years old	107-162 WPM
4	9-10 years old	123-180 WPM
5	10-11 years old	139-194 WPM
6-8	12-14 years old	150-204 WPM
High School	14-18 years old	200-300 WPM
College	18-23 years old	300-350 WPM
Adults	23 years old and above	220-350 WPM

Section:

PARAGRAPH WRITING II

Chapter Topic:

FROM PARAGRAPH TO COMPOSITION

In this chapter, we will try to learn how a paragraph can be expanded into a composition. Let's discuss some major aspects.

EXPANDING A PARAGRAPH

If you can write a logical, coherent paragraph, you will be able to expand a paragraph into multiple paragraphs and it is called the art of composition. Composition is a type of writing consisting of

multiple connected or related paragraphs on a certain topic. Composition is based on the expansion of the first or *paragraph of introduction*. You will notice that the *paragraph of introduction* will not have a topic sentence; rather it contains a controlling idea that can be expanded into a composition consisting of multiple connected paragraphs. So, the controlling idea is very important for the expansion of a paragraph into a composition. Let's discuss the controlling idea.

Controlling Idea Vs. Topic Sentence

We have studied and understood the concept of the Topic Sentence in the 1st Semester where we discussed that topic sentence in a paragraph is the sentence that presents one important topic or idea. In that paragraph, all the other sentences in the form of supporting sentences will support the topic sentence by highlighting some further relevant aspects in that line of specific topic originated by the topic sentence. A good **topic sentence** is based on a topic and a limiting statement:

Topic Sentence = Topic + Limiting Statement

In this way, we limit our topic of discussion. One good way to limit the topic is to make use of keywords or phrases in the topic sentence. These keywords or phrases are also called controlling words or phrases because they control the organization of the paragraph.

On the other hand, a specific sentence in the *paragraph of introduction* that narrows down the choices given in it is called the controlling idea of the composition. The controlling idea focuses on the narrowed down choices and are elaborated separately in different but connected paragraphs. These elaborated paragraphs take the form of a composition. Therefore, a controlling idea is more powerful and more general than a topic sentence. It controls not only a single paragraph but also an entire composition. Above all, it mentions the main idea of the entire composition just like the topic sentence of a separate paragraph in that composition. Last but not least, the controlling idea will be the part of the *paragraph of introduction* and remember then you will not find a topic sentence in the *paragraph of introduction*. That is, the *paragraph of introduction* is not considered a proper paragraph because it misses a topic sentence which is compulsory for a proper paragraph.